7.12 The Tuba-Zangariyye Dolmen Field, Israel

Yael Alef, Eran Mordohovich, Uri Berger

Introduction and management context

The Tuba-Zangariyye dolmen field demonstrates how the assessment of cultural significance aided in incorporating the remains into a development plan, thereby reducing destruction that threatened them. It illustrates a shift in the Israel Antiquities Authority's (IAA) approach to preserving dolmens in situ.

Located on the southern edge of the Tuba-Zangariyye village in northern Israel, the dolmen field (area of megalithic burial structures) was threatened in 2015 when the Ministry of Housing and Construction proposed a residential neighbourhood development on the site. This proposal was made without consulting the IAA, although the area is designated as an antiquities site under the Antiquities Law, which requires IAA approval for such developments. In response to the proposal, an archaeological survey mapped the remains within the planning area. At this stage, significance assessment was not conducted, resulting in only a few dolmens being identified for preservation in isolated locations. The IAA conditionally approved the development plan, contingent on a salvage excavation being carried out. This ultimately condemned most of the dolmens and the megalithic landscape to destruction. As the planning progressed, it only partially adhered to the IAA conditions, and infrastructure was planned close to the remaining dolmens, which would have practically eliminated them had the plan been implemented.

This reflects the common approach in Israel until recently, where the dolmens did not receive appropriate attention from most archaeologists and have been largely overlooked by development and major archaeological enterprises. With the growing development pressures in the last decades, the practice of salvage excavation as a management policy has resulted in the destruction of numerous dolmens in the Golan Heights and the Korazim Plateau. Despite their historical and cultural significance, dozens of dolmens have been damaged by basalt mining in the Golan Heights and the Korazim Plateau for the construction of ports and the development of towns and villages. Even in instances where the dolmens themselves were preserved, their setting in the landscape and context were often destroyed.

Figure 60: IAA archaeologist surveying a dolmen in the Tuba-Zangariyye field, with the village in the background (Photo taken by E. Mordohovich, 2019).

Fortunately, that was not the end of the story for the Tuba-Zangariyye dolmen field. In 2019, the development plan was expanded, and consequently, an additional archaeological survey was conducted in the expanded area (Fig.60). During this time, the IAA became more aware of contemporary practices in archaeological resource management. This included a recognition of the policy presumption for the preservation of archaeological heritage in situ, which is enshrined as one of the principles in the Valletta Convention, as well as the need for an integrated approach to the conservation of archaeological heritage. This awareness was further complemented by recognizing the importance of a holistic approach to the cultural landscape and incorporating the concept of value-based management. The renewed survey thus presented an opportunity to clarify the significance of the dolmens and the importance of the megalithic cultural landscape. It also allowed for the establishment of new guidelines to integrate the remains into the development plan.

The legal system

The Israeli Antiquities Law of 1978 designates the IAA to oversee and manage the country's archaeological sites and artifacts. According to the law, "antiquity" is defined as "Any object, whether detached or fixed, which was made by man before the year 1700 of the general era and includes anything subsequently added thereto which forms an integral part thereof". An "antiquity site" indicates an area that contains antiquities.

Under the law, the IAA is responsible for conducting archaeological surveys and registering antiquity sites. It is also tasked with regulating any construction or development that may impact these sites. Any proposed development within the area of a registered antiquity site must receive approval from the IAA. When a development plan is submitted for approval, the IAA will either conduct a survey or trial trenches and/or excavation to identify potential remains. Based on the results, it will decide whether to approve the plan with no further conditions, reject the plan, or require salvage excavations before permitting development activities. The IAA may also mandate mitigation measures to protect archaeological sites during construction.

More than 30,000 antiquity sites are currently registered under the Antiquities Law. However, while the law effectively regulates the discovery, excavation, and ownership of antiquities, it lacks robust tools for designating sites for preservation. As a matter of fact, archaeological sites that merit preservation must be statutorily protected under the 1965 Planning and Building Law.

The evaluation system

In Israel, the authorities do not implement a formal evaluation system for designating archaeological sites for preservation. The following text adopts a significance assessment information model (Alef, 2021) and guidelines for cultural significance assessment developed by the author. These guidelines are intended for the training of Archaeological Resource Management (ARM) practitioners in academia and the Israel Antiquities Authority (IAA). They are based on a Context-Based Significance Assessment (CBSA) approach, which aims to place the site within broader historical processes, enabling the perception of broad patterns and how individual resources fit within these patterns. This approach also helps to explain spatial and cultural interconnections (Briuer and Mathers, 1997; Carman, 2015; Hardesty and Little, 2009; Mathers et al, 2005).

CBSA evaluates a site within its historical themes and geographical contexts. Common criteria for evaluating archaeological sites include the period; quality of the remains (in terms of integrity and preservation); rarity; representativeness; vulnerability; documentation; aesthetics; and research potential. However, it should be noted that in addition to the changing nature of significance in relation to cultural agendas, academic and professional literature does not specify precisely what needs to be done to assess these qualities. Generally, these qualities refer to academic and scientific value, changes over time, local and community values, and wider public benefits (Carman, 2015).

The CBSA model suggests complementing the site description with the following steps:

1. Identify the cultural elements and context components, including (a) typological, structural, and geographical context; (b) historical information referring to figures, events, and processes related to the site or its context; (c) cultural themes related to stories and figures, artistic themes depicted in artifacts, traditions, and practices.

2. Articulate the cultural significance, explaining why these elements are significant.
3. Contextualize the cultural significance in relation to the themes, demonstrating how the broader context amplifies this significance.
4. Compare the site to other similar sites to highlight its uniqueness or representativeness, including the integrity of the remains. Consider factors such as rarity, workmanship, and artistic quality.
5. Write a concise summary integrating all the previous points into a cohesive narrative. Where relevant in the description or cultural significance assessment, refer to the quality of information, such as available sources, the richness of data, as well as uncertainties or different explanations for phenomena.

Description of the site

The Tuba-Zangariyye dolmen field is situated on a hill in the basalt Korazim Plateau, which stretches in the Jordan Rift Valley, between the Sea of Galilee in the south and the Hula Valley in the north (Fig.61). This field is part of the larger Korazim dolmen field which is the western extension of the vast megalithic field of southern Syria and upper Jordan.

Throughout history, the plateau was home to semi-nomadic cattle herders and pastoralists who lived in temporary dwellings, leaving behind stone animal pens as a common feature in the area. However, the most significant archaeological elements on the plateau are approximately 500 dolmens and a few hundred more tumuli that dominate the landscape. These are dated to the Intermediate Bronze Age, around the end of the 3rd to the early 2nd millennia BCE (4,500-4,000 years ago) and represent the latest in a series of megalithic monuments of the Jordan Valley and the Golan Heights (Stepansky, 2005).

In 1877, Herbert Kitchener, who later commanded the British Empire Army during World War One, reported that while surveying the area of the Zangariyye tribes for the Palestine Exploration Fund, they discovered the first perfect dolmen he had seen in the country, which was called Hajr ed Dum, or "the stone of blood"

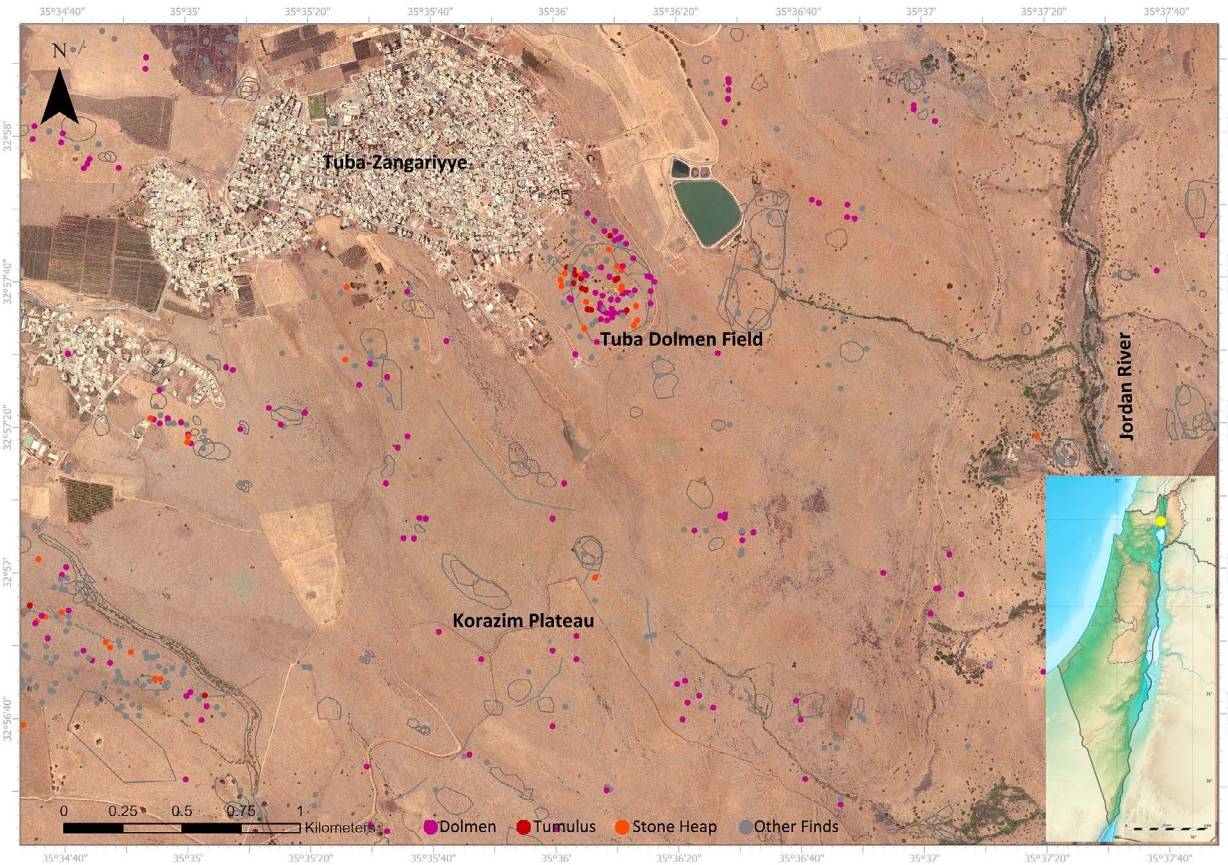

Figure 61: Survey map of the Tuba-Zangariyye dolmen field on the Korazim Plateau showing its dense concentration of dolmens. (GIS map prepared by Y. Alef, 2024)

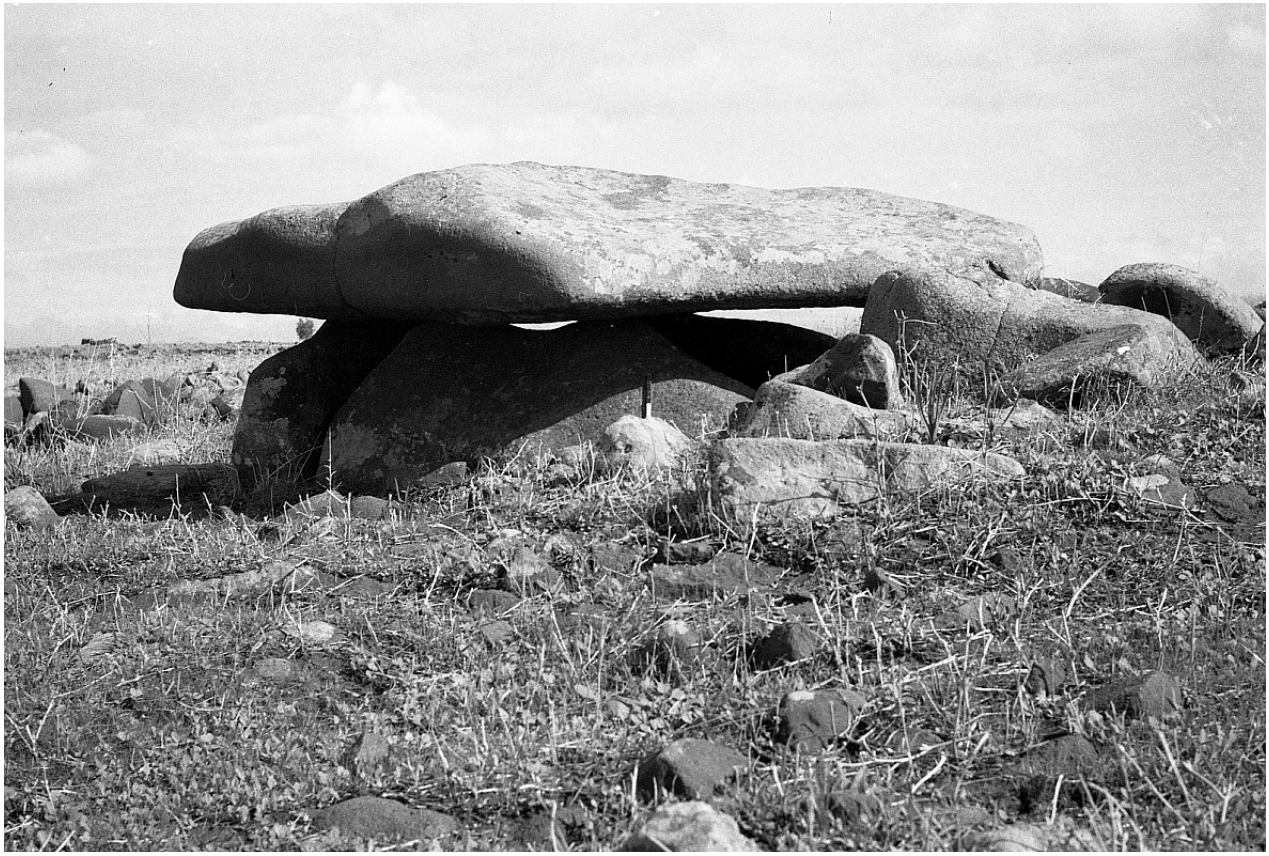

Figure 62: An historic photo of dolmen in the Tuba-Zangariyye vicinity, possibly the Hajar ed Dumm dolmen mentioned by Kitchner in 1877. (B. Rothenberg, 1955, Meitar Collection, The Pritzker Family National Photography Collection, The National Library of Israel)

(Kitchener, 1877). This dolmen was part of a large field of dolmens on the Korazim Plateau, identified by Karge in 1917. The field was later included in a report on Prehistoric Galilee by Francis Turville-Petre in the 1920s, who also excavated 24 dolmens in the area. Following Moshe Stekelis in the 1960s and Claire Epstein in the 1970s, research continued into the 1990s with the IAA survey of Israel by Yosef Stepansky, who documented 578 dolmens on the Korazim Plateau. A few dolmens were also excavated as part of local salvage excavations (Berger and Sharon, 2018).

The dolmens located in Tuba-Zangariyye form part of the ancient landscape that was already familiar during Biblical times. It is possible that they are related to references in the Bible about giants who inhabited the eastern Transjordan. As stated in Deuteronomy 2:21, "That also was accounted a land of giants: giants dwelt therein in old time...". Among them was Og, the giant king of the Bashan. Additionally, there are references to dolmen in the Korazim area, which may be the "tombs" described in the miracle of the pigs where Jesus casts out demons from the body of a madman. Mark 5:2-3 states, "When Jesus got out of the boat, a man with an impure spirit came from the tombs to meet him. This man lived in the tombs..." (Stepansky, 2005)

The Tuba-Zangariyye field includes more than 65 dolmens and more than 20 tumuli over an area of about 0.5km^2. It consists of several types of dolmens, most of which are small with 1.5 - 3m long closed chambers and 1-2 covering stones. The size of the covering stones varies, with an average of 0.5 x 1.5 x 3m, but some single stones may weigh as much as 15 tons. Some of the dolmens stand out conspicuously and can be seen from afar due to a large capstone that covers the dolmen chamber or its tumulus (see Fig.62).

Another type of dolmen is covered by tumuli, consisting of various-sized fieldstones. In many instances, one can discern within them or around their circumference remains of walls, adding an even more commanding and monumental appearance. The average sizes of tumuli are 5 to 10m in diameter and 1-2m in height, but some reach sizes of 15-20m x 3m. Those dolmens without a tumulus are usually enclosed by a stone circle or by scattered stones placed evenly or without order around the structure (Stepansky, 2005).